



SIPRA DAS

Journey of Gender Equity

DELHI The fairly sombre and conventional act of tabling a bill in the hallowed precincts of Parliament turned into a display of shielding tactics that would have been more in place during navy battles. Law Minister H.R. Bhardwaj introduced the much-delayed, hotly-contested Women's Reservation Bill in the Rajya Sabha with a two-pronged move that prevented its most bitter opponents from stalling

proceedings.

Any minister tabling a bill normally does so from the first row of the treasury benches. Bhardwaj, though, was tactically stationed in the second row flanked—symbolically and for strategic reasons—by two women ministers, Kumari Selja and Ambika Soni. To add to the woman power in the minister's vicinity, Congress MPs Renuka Chowdhury and Jayanti Natarajan were also stationed around him

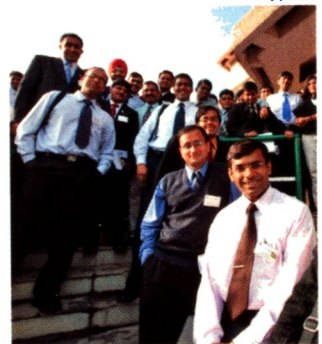
DIVIDED HOUSE: The Bill will allow 33% reservation to prevent rushes from agitated SP and JD(U) members who have opposed the bill vehemently pushing for an OBC quota within it. Chowdhury proved to be an able bodyguard to the law minister, pushing SP's Abu Azmi away as he tried to snatch the Bill from Bhardwaj's hands.

This is the sixth, and perhaps the most theatric, outing for the Women's Reservation Bill in Parliament. It aims to amend the Constitution to reserve one-third of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies. It began its optimistic journey to gender equity in politics under the H.D. Deve Gowda government in 1998. Since then, it has lurched sporadically into prominence due to its frequent and unsuccessful reintroductions under the NDA in 1999, 2002 and 2003. For the record, 539 candidates were elected to the 14th Lok Sabha of which only 44—or eight per cent—were women.

Relative Status

HYDERABAD The Sixth Pay Commission's controversial recommendations are creating more heartburn now that the fine print has been analysed. It will bring about a fundamental change in the way status is defined in the bureaucracy. Currently, basic pay is the parameter to define the status of a position. A higher basic pay means a higher position. If the Srikrishna

RAVI S SAHANI



Pay Commission is pro-IAS

Commission report is implemented, the grade pay, instead of basic pay, will define the status of a position. When the grade pay is equivalent, higher total emoluments including all special pays will define a higher status. Significantly, the commission has converted all the eight pay scales applicable to the IAS with a corresponding grade pay. So, in PB-3 for example, the grade pays of Rs 6,500, 7,500 and 8,300 have been created which are exclusive to the IAS. Representative associations of other services perceive a pro-IAS bias to reduce the status position of all other all India services by a staggering 40 per cent with only the IAS not only keeping its statuses intact, but doubling it at junior levels.

by Amarnath K. Menon

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